

# Definition Drift Debate Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

|            |                        |      |                         |
|------------|------------------------|------|-------------------------|
| Category   | Knowledge and Language | Time | 25-35 min               |
| Difficulty | Medium                 | ID   | definition-drift-debate |

Big idea: Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

## Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

## Concrete Stimulus Packet

|                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 1: Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust. | Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.                                                                |
| <b>Definition Drift Debate Stimulus B</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 2: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.                                   | Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.                                                                                        |
| <b>Definition Drift Debate Reveal / Twist</b> | Student-facing stimulus 3: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.                                   | Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context. |

## Actual Lesson Questions

| # | Question for students                                                                    |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | After inspecting Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim? |
| 2 | Which exact detail from Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A did you use as evidence?      |
| 3 | What did you infer beyond the evidence?                                                  |
| 4 | How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?                                 |
| 5 | What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?                         |
| 6 | Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?                                    |

## Ready-to-Use Examples

- Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving.
- Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality.

## Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

### Activity Steps

1. Choose a term such as intelligence, health, art, risk, fairness, or success.
2. Groups receive different definitions and list what each definition includes and excludes.
3. Students apply each definition to borderline examples.
4. Groups debate which definition is most useful for a specific purpose.
5. Debrief how definitions can shape what evidence counts.

### Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

| What I noticed | What I inferred | Evidence | Confidence |
|----------------|-----------------|----------|------------|
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |

### TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?
- Who should have authority to define contested terms?
- When does changing a definition improve knowledge and when does it manipulate it?

### Knowledge Questions

- Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?
- How do definitions shape evidence and disagreement?
- Who has authority over shared meanings?

### Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a term such as 'intelligence', 'health', 'art', or 'expert' across contexts. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

### Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...